



A PERSONAL STORY

THE GIRL I USED TO BE

by Niniola Fathia

"Maybe I wasn't really fading away after all."



A story about change, hope, and finding your way back.

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The Girl I Used to Be

Sometimes, you don't realize you're losing yourself until you look back and realize how different you feel.

I have thought about writing this for a while, but I never really knew where to start.

Maybe because this isn't just a story.

It's about me.

It's about a version of me that I remember so clearly, but somehow can't completely recognize anymore.

There was a time when I was a very determined girl. I had plans for myself. I had things I wanted to become, places I wanted to go, and a future I had already started imagining in my head.

I loved reading.

I loved writing.

I used to journal my thoughts, even the ones that didn't make much sense. Writing was one of the ways I understood myself. I was also a kind of person who could understand things easily. If I didn't understand something I would keep trying until I did.

I had this feeling that I could figure things out.

I don't think there is one particular day when I lost myself. It happened quietly, through so many little things that I didn't notice at first.

I stopped reading.

I stopped writing.

I stopped journaling.

And somehow, even understanding things became harder for me. I would read something and realize that I had read it without actually understanding what I had just seen.

That scared me.

Because I knew myself.

Then there was coding.

I started going to coding classes because I wanted to learn something that was useful for my future. I was excited about it at first. But when I got there, there were so many things I didn't understand.

I tried to follow.

I tried to catch up.

I tried to make sense out of everything.

And when I couldn't I went back to YouTube classes, hoping that maybe I could understand it better if I learned at my own pace.

I was trying to teach myself again.

A lot was happening around me at the same time.

I was waiting for admission.

At first, I was hopeful. I kept imagining what life would look like once I finally got that admission. I had plans. I was ready for the next chapter.

But the waiting became exhausting.

Days turned into weeks, and the hope I had started with slowly became hard to hold on to.

I began wondering if the things I had planned for myself would actually happen.

Even my dreams had changed.

For a long time, I had planned to study Automobile Engineering. That was the goal I had in my head. I had already pictured myself going down that path.

But somehow, along the way, Computer Science became the course I started looking towards.

And although I eventually began to like Computer Science, even that excitement started getting difficult to hold on to.

It felt like everything was changing at once.

The girl who always had a plan suddenly didn't know what she was doing.

The girl that was determined started losing hope.

The girl who loved reading stopped opening her books.

The girl who loved writing stopped filling her journal.

The girl who was trying to learn coding started feeling like she wasn't good enough to understand it.

And, perhaps the part that hurt me the most, I stopped reading my Quran the way I used to.

I knew something was wrong because I was slowly becoming distant from things that once made me feel like myself.

I wasn't just losing interest in one thing.

I felt like I was losing interest in everything around me.

And I didn't know how to explain it.

I just felt like...

I was fading.

Not in a way that everyone could see.

I could still laugh.

I could still talk.

I could still go about my day.

But somewhere inside me, I felt tired.

It was like I was watching myself become a stranger to myself.

Sometimes I would think about the girl I used to be and wonder where she went.

Where was all that determination?

Where was the girl who could keep trying until she understood?

Where was the girl who would write her thoughts down instead of keeping everything inside?

Where was the girl who had so much faith in her future?

I didn't have an answer.

And maybe I still don't,

But somewhere along the way, I realized something.

Maybe I don't need to find the exact girl I used to be.

Maybe I just need to find my way back to the parts of her that still exist in me.

So I started trying,

Not perfectly.

Not all at once.

Just slowly.

I started trying to read again.

I started writing again, even when words didn't come out the way I wanted them to.

I tried to return to my Quran.

I kept learning coding, even when I didn't understand everything.

I kept waiting for my admission, even when I felt like giving up.

And I started reminding myself that not understanding something doesn't mean that I'm incapable of learning it.

Not knowing what comes next doesn't mean that I have no future.

And changing my plans doesn't mean that I have failed.

Maybe life isn't always going the way I planned it.

Maybe the girl who wanted Automobile Engineering can grow into the girl who finds something she loves in Computer Science.

Maybe the girl who lost interest in writing can eventually become a girl who writes again.

Maybe the girl who stopped reading can pick up a book tomorrow.

Maybe the girl who felt distant from her Quran can slowly find her way back.

Maybe I don't have to fix everything at once.

Maybe I just have to keep coming back.

If you're reading this and you feel like you've lost yourself too.....

I want you to know something from someone who is still figuring out herself:

You don't have to have your life figured out right now.

If you fail at something, try again.

If you don't understand something, learn it again.

If you stopped reading, pick up the book again.

If you've been distant from Allah, don't think you're too far to return. Just take that first step back.

And if you're waiting for something—a school admission, an opportunity, an answer, a new beginning—please don't let the waiting make you believe that your life has stopped.

Sometimes we become so focused on the chapter we are waiting for that we forget we are still living in the one we're in.

I don't know exactly where my story is going yet.

I'm still learning.

I'm still waiting.

I'm still trying to understand myself.

I'm still figuring out my future.

I'm still finding my way back to my books, my writing, my Quran, my dreams, and most importantly, myself.

But this time, I'm not going to pressure myself to become the old me.

I'm going to grow into a new me.

A me who knows that life can change.

A me who knows that losing direction doesn't mean losing the whole journey.

A me who knows that it's okay to start again.

Because maybe I wasn't really fading away after all.

Maybe I was simply growing through a part of my life that I didn't understand yet.

And if you're going through that part too, I hope you remember this:

You are not behind. You are not finished. You are not lost forever.

Take it one at a time.

Come back to yourself slowly.

And even if all you can do is take one tiny step—Take it.

A LITTLE ADVICE BEFORE YOU GO

A Little Advice Before You Go

Psychologist Kristin Neff, who has researched self-compassion, teaches that we should learn to treat ourselves with the same kindness and understanding we would give to someone we care about when they are struggling.

And honestly, I think that is something many of us forget.

Sometimes we are so hard on ourselves. We look at who we used to be and wonder, “What happened to me?” We see other people moving forward and start feeling like we’re behind. We make mistakes and begin to feel like we’ve failed.

But struggling doesn’t mean you’re failing.

You don’t have everything figured out. You don’t have to become the person you used to be. And you don’t have to fix your whole life in one day.

Give yourself permission to start again.

Niniola Fathia